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Altered Perceptions of Sleep: Performativity, Duration, and Embodied Relationships in
Contemporary Sinophone Art

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Abstract

This dissertation examines how contemporary Sinophone artists construct disturbed perceptual states associated with sleep through performance, spatial practice, and photographic staging. I argue that disturbed states of sleep, analyzed through embodied, phenomenological, and culturally embedded dimensions, shift narratives that treat sleep as metaphor or a private symptom into a conversation that recognizes material processes and cultural forces, rendering such states visible and meaningful within contemporary art. Methodologically, the dissertation brings together phenomenological insights, an anthropological perspective, and an account of threshold states, while critically avoiding overreliance on psychoanalysis. Employing a comparative analysis of works by Duan Yingmei, Li Liao, Peng Wu, and Chen Wei, the research does not suggest that the artists are disturbed; rather, the archetypes of sleep anomalies are externalized as symptoms in these artists' works. Through interactions of body, space, and medium, the artists' tactics manipulate duration, embodiment, and environment, constructing a material interpretation of disturbed states of sleep and connecting such states to cultural quagmires. While Western clinical frameworks primarily characterize sleep disturbances as a neurological phenomenon, Sinophone artistic practices offer interpretations that draw on folkloric traditions, embodied memory, and supernatural elements. Across the globe, the art-historical lexicon has adopted a Western dictionary, yet this repertoire cannot easily be placed within the Sinophonic language. Sinophone artists recast sleep disturbances as a culturally meaningful experience, blending symptoms with haunting and connecting individual sensations to collective stories of supernatural encounters. This perspective is supported by research on the prevalence of supernatural explanations for sleep paralysis across cultures.

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Introduction

Sleep disturbances remain one of the most hauntingly unexplored territories in scholarly discourse, specifically pertaining to disturbed states of sleep that occur at the thresholds between consciousness and unconsciousness. These states are frequently described through sensations of perceptual distortion, bodily immobility, and spatial disorientation. Disturbed states of sleep encompass experiences that resist transparent categorization as either waking or dreaming, and instead occupy an unstable interval in which sensory perception, bodily awareness, and environmental orientation are fundamentally altered. Existing scholarship, which is extremely limited in scope, has largely confined sleep disturbances to the frameworks of neuroscience and clinical psychology. This dissertation expands the boundaries of disturbed states of sleep as they are restricted in art history scholarship. The current hypothesis that articulates the shape and meaning of sleep disturbances within a broader framework is confined by society and current associations in scholarship.¹ This dissertation will approach such states through broader methods of examining how contemporary Sinophone artists construct analogous conditions through performativity, employing modes of duration and spatial intervention. Rather than focusing

¹ It is important to note that Chinese and other Asian cultures did not become prominent within the global art historical narrative until the 20th century. [Department of Asian Art, "Traditional Chinese Painting in the Twentieth Century," The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2004] The terminology and language commonly used in art history are rooted in Western frameworks. Due to Western influence, Asian art was incorporated into a broader understanding of art history, but this inclusion comes with significant limitations. For example, when museums in Europe and North America first began collecting Chinese ink paintings, these works were often categorized as "decorative arts" rather than "fine art." [The Metropolitan Museum of Art, "Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Chinese Paintings from the Robert H. Ellsworth Collection in The Metropolitan Museum of Art," 2001] This classification of "decorative arts" was diminished in status compared to oil paintings from Europe. Similarly, calligraphy, which holds deep cultural significance in many Asian societies, was not traditionally viewed as "art" in the Western sense but rather as an integral, everyday practice. [Asian Studies, "Calligraphy in East Asia: Art, Communication, and Symbolism," Association for Asian Studies, Accessed May 11, 2026] For instance, in China, calligraphy has been regarded as an essential cultural and moral pursuit, closely linked to scholarship and personal cultivation, rather than solely an aesthetic object. [Hung, Ruyu, "Self-Cultivation Through the Art of Calligraphy: From Past to the Future," *Beijing International Review of Education* 4, no. 3 (2022): 396-407, <https://doi.org/10.1163/25902539-04030009>.] The Western framing of Asian art history therefore imposes constraints that can obscure these cultural distinctions, as it tends to prioritize medium and visual appearance over process and meaning. Additionally, while there are numerous medical terms for different sleep conditions, within Sinophone contexts, these terms can be restrictive and challenging to communicate.

solely on internal or psychological conditions as they manifest in performative mediums, this study will shift the main narrative from representations of sleep to productions of experiences that destabilize the viewer's relation to time, space, and embodiment.

The historical understanding of disturbed sleep has been interpreted through culturally specific frameworks. In Sinophone contexts, the phenomenon usually referred to as *guǐ yā shēn* (鬼压床, ghost pressing) describes a state in which an individual, while lying between sleep and wakefulness, experiences the inability to move accompanied by a sense of external pressure or presence.² Typically, such interpretations attribute these conditions to supernatural forces; however, they also articulate a broader experiential structure defined by immobility, heightened awareness, and perceptual ambiguity.³ The gap evidenced within Sinophone artists' uses of folklore and cultural memory gives sleep conditions a unique, viscerally embodied form that

² Terms such as *guǐ yā shēn* (鬼压床) ("ghostly" interpretations from Hong Kong, Taiwan, Malaysia, and outside mainland China), "ghost pressing down on the chest" or "ghost pressing," are used within Sinophone contexts. Sleep disturbances within Sinophone culture are seen within a spiritual mode or folkloric narratives rather than a medical phenomena that Western medicine has diagnosed as an REM condition, commonly known as sleep paralysis. This interpretation of ghost pressing is crucial to the dissertation's main themes pertaining to disturbed states of sleep.

³ Sinophone stories such as Chu T'ien-hsin's *The Old Capital* (2007), Li Ang's "Bloody Sacrifice of the Makeup Face" (1997), and Giddens Ko's *The Legend of Fate Hunters* (Lie ming shi chuanqi 獵命師傳奇) series (2005–2013; twenty volumes in total) masterfully employ ghost narratives to craft a literature that vividly explores the complexities, anxieties, and aspirations of the Chinese diaspora. [Jen-Yi Hsu, "Ghosts in the City: Mourning and Melancholia in Zhu Tianxin's *The Old Capital*," *Comparative Literature Studies* 41, no. 4 (2004): 546–564, <https://doi.org/10.1353/cls.2005.0006>.] For example, in *The Old Capital* (2007), Chu T'ien-hsin interlaces the spectral presence of lost relatives with scenes where memories of the homeland intrude on the protagonist's daily life, allowing the past to haunt the present in subtle yet powerful ways. Li Ang's "Bloody Sacrifice of the Makeup Face" (1997) uses the motif of a vengeful ghost to echo suppressed female voices and unspoken traumas, with episodes in which the protagonist is visited by a spirit seeking justice for historical wrongs. Similarly, Giddens Ko's *Fate Hunters* (2005–2013) series frequently blends urban fantasy with the ghostly apparitions of ancestors, weaving supernatural confrontations into the characters' struggles with questions of belonging and identity. By weaving these supernatural elements with everyday realities, these authors evoke the lingering presence of history, tradition, and memory in the lives of displaced individuals and communities [Di-Kai Chao, "Exploring Sinophone Liminality in Contemporary Chinese Fiction: Ghost Narratives and the Contouring of Invisible Realms," *Journal of the European Association for Chinese Studies* 6, no. 2 (2025), <https://doi.org/10.25365/jeacs.2025.6.2.bai>.] These works highlight broader themes of collective narrative, such as migration, identity formation, and cultural survival, connecting deeply with the social fabric of the human psyche. [Chaoyang Liao, "From Shame to Freedom: Undoing Spectral Identity in Li Ang's *Seeing Ghosts*," in *The Oxford Handbook of Modern Chinese Literatures*, Carlos Rojas and Andrea Bachner, Oxford Handbooks (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016), <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199383313.013.37>.] Through these evocative tales, Sinophone folklore not only illuminates the cultural framework discussed in this dissertation but also reveals how Sinophone culture uses modes of the spiritual and the ghostly to articulate both personal traumas and communal bonds, offering a unique lens into the emotional landscapes of diasporic experience. [Chao, "Exploring Sinophone Liminality in Contemporary Chinese Fiction," 2025.]

reveals the layers of experience that clinical language cannot capture.⁴ Even though this clinical language strips the experience of its terror and its texture, Western medical discourse categorizes these experiences as neurological events associated often with hallucinations.⁵ What one culture dismisses as a misfiring brain, another recognizes as something ancient and insistent.⁶ These descriptions, while resonating with clinical accounts of hypnagogia, differ in their attributions towards agency and meaning.⁷ Instead of treating these frameworks as explanatory models to be

⁴ Sleep narratives are seen throughout Sinophone culture in different ways. An example of this can be seen in depictions of Mao Zedong. Most often, he is seen sleeping within modes of artistic expression, as he was and still is a controversial topic in historical discourse. Mao Zedong is an important figure in Sinophone culture as well as discussed in global histories. Mao Zedong is most notable for leading China from the PRC's establishment in 1949 until his death in 1976. His main recognition is for his role as the Chairman of the Chinese Communist Party. Zedong was known for having an irregular sleep schedule as well as is depicted in contemporary post-Cultural Revolution art as sleeping in order to strip away his deified, omnipotent status. [Jesse Hamlin, "Chinese Artist Sui Jianguo Puts Mao to Rest in Colorful Metaphor," 2005, <https://lalouver.com/html/gallery-history-images/other-resources/SJ-SFGate-Hamlin-2005.pdf>.]

⁵ Clinical explanations attribute sleep disturbances such as the condition of sleep paralysis to REM atonia, in which the body remains physiologically paralyzed while the mind claws its way back into consciousness, straining against an invisible restraint it cannot name and cannot lift. [Maheen Farooq and Fatima Anjum, "Sleep Paralysis," *StatPearls* (Treasure Island, FL: StatPearls Publishing, 2023), <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK562322/>] These models effectively describe the neurophysiological mechanisms underlying this condition and clarify its association with REM sleep. This enables clinicians to differentiate it from other sleep disorders, thereby offering explanatory power with direct implications for diagnosis and treatment. The precision with which biomedical accounts trace the neural and bodily, which correlates to sleep paralysis, has expanded our capacity to recognize its prevalence, understand its triggers, and devise interventions that alleviate somatic suffering. Within this framework, however, the experience is often flattened into something coldly neurological and presumed universal, its visual and sensory disturbances reduced to misfirings of the brain, aberrations to be cataloged and corrected. Yet such interpretations are not only insufficient; they are an intent act of erasure. Scientific accounts strip the experience of its full, terrifying weight, its cultural density, its historical depth. They refuse to reckon with the fact that sleep paralysis is not a biological event alone; moreover, it is also a culturally saturated encounter, one shaped by centuries of belief, by the very grammar of the languages through which it is named and narrated, and by historically specific understandings of what lies beyond the edge of the visible world.

⁶ There are many different folkloric references relating to sleep disturbances. *guǐ yā shēn* (鬼压床) is used because of its importance to the dissertations central argument, but there are other terms such as *jiangshi* (僵尸 or 殭屍) known as "Chinese hopping zombies" which is another folkloric Sinophone topic related to sleep disturbances.

⁷ Hypnagogia refers to the transitional, "threshold consciousness" state between wakefulness and sleep, in which the brain is not fully conscious, but is partially aware or attuned to its consciousness, while the body begins to shut down. This state often associates with vivid, involuntary sensory experiences. Such as hallucinations, lucid thoughts, muscle jerks, or sleep paralysis. According to Daniel Yetman's article, *What is Hypnagogia, the State between Wakefulness and Sleep?* as well as in Romain Ghibellini's and Beat Meir's 2023 study, *Hypnagogic states are quite common: Self-reported prevalence, modalities, and gendered differences*, this state is experienced by about 70 percent of people as they fall asleep. [Daniel Yetman, "What Is Hypnagogia, the State between Wakefulness and Sleep?" Healthline Media, 2020, <https://www.healthline.com/health/hypnagogia#inducing-hypnagogia>.][Ghibellini Romain and Beat Meir, "Hypnagogic States Are Quite Common: Self-Reported Prevalence, Modalities, and Gender Differences," *Consciousness and Cognition* 115, 103582 (2023): 82, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.concog.2023.103582>.]

verified or dismissed, they can be understood as culturally embedded ways of articulating the bodily experience.⁸

The canon of liminality mentioned in this dissertation needs to be understood in order to contextualize contemporary Sinophone artists' use of their mediums.⁹ The narratives surrounding "liminality" take on a position in art history to communicate thresholds and ideas that are uncanny. This concept originates in the anthology of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, who often used the term to articulate transitional phases or in-between states. While this term has been overused and adopted in art historical discourse, in order to account for ambiguity and perceptual instability, its implementation has created an overly expansive pleonasm that serves as a basic descriptor in the art historical lexicon. The original formula for liminality refers to a precise, structured phase within transformation, instead of being an open-ended diagnosis. While it is important to know this term and its function, this dissertation will not solely rely on it as a primary skeleton and will instead pay attention to how certain conditions, such as temporal disruption, spatial disorientation, and altered embodiment, are built within artistic practice. This turning point will permit the study to observe a precise analysis of how disturbed states

⁸ Arthur Kleinman argues that illness positions itself into a culturally interpreted experience structured by what he terms explanatory models.; Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.; Esther Olunu et al., "Sleep Paralysis, a Medical Condition with a Diverse Cultural Interpretation," *International Journal of Applied and Basic Medical Research* 8, no.3, (2018): 137-142, https://doi.org/10.4103/ijabmr.IJABMR_19_18; I. Carvalho et al., "Cultural explanations of sleep paralysis: The spiritual phenomena," (*European Psychiatry* 33, 2016): S401, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2016.01.1434>; Yun-Kwok Wing, Sharon T. Lee, and Char-Nie Chen, "Sleep Paralysis in Chinese: Ghost Oppression Phenomenon in Hong Kong," *Sleep* 17, no. 7 (1994), <https://doi.org/10.1093/sleep/17.7.609>; Esther Olunu et al., "Sleep Paralysis, a Medical Condition with a Diverse Cultural Interpretation," *International Journal of Applied and Basic Medical Research* 8, no. 3, (2018): 137-142, https://doi.org/10.4103/ijabmr.IJABMR_19_18.

⁹ Di-kai Chao, "Exploring Sinophone Liminality in Contemporary Chinese Fiction: Ghost Narratives and the Contouring of Invisible Realms," *Journal of the European Association for Chinese Studies* 6, no. 2 (2025): 158-179, <https://doi.org/10.25365/jeacs.2025.6.2.158-179>.

associated with sleep are formed through performance and environment, rather than subsumed under a wider grouping of “in-betweenness.”¹⁰

The artists examined in this dissertation, rather than being directly illustrative, use their works to engage with underlying conditions representative of sleep disturbances. The works articulate modes of immobility, repetition, perceptual instability, and altered temporality. These methods are emphasized through the material and spatial properties of performativity. In this sense, disturbed sleep does not implicate the subject as a depiction, and paradoxically approaches it as experiential conditions that can be constructed and encountered within artistic practice. Crucially, this transition from representation to production is central to the argument that follows. Although there are many different sleep disorders and culturally embedded narratives tied to sleep and dreaming states, the dissertation will not diagnose these disorders associated with the artist's works. This study will treat these case studies as an examination of sleep and how disturbed states associated with sleep are represented in performance. The artistic mediums that will be discussed construct perceptions differently, however do so through performative modes.

The methods used in the dissertation are not applied literally through the psychoanalytic lens. The four artists discussed are not disturbed individuals, but the tropes of sleep disturbance are used in their works, suggesting possible cultural issues. While sleep disturbance and art historical language come from a Western framework, the lens of psychoanalysis cannot be easily mapped onto other cultures. Whether it is or is not a proper disjuncture is not a simple identifier. This study examines psychoanalysis in relation to a specific condition. However, it is not being pathologized in regard to the artists themselves. In this respect, the psychoanalytic approach is associated with sleep issues as a symptom in these artists' works.

¹⁰ Arnold van Gennep, *The Rites of Passage*, (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1909), 7-228; Victor Turner, “‘Liminality and Communitas,’ in the Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure,” 1969, <https://voidnetwork.gr/wp-content/uploads/2016/09/Liminality-and-Communitas-by-Victor-Turner.pdf>.

Beginning with a theoretical framework provides a basis for understanding these conditions displayed within the atmosphere of performance. The work of Jean Ma, whose writing on cinema and sleep exemplifies the instability of perception at the threshold between waking and dreaming.¹¹ According to Ma, states connected with sleep should not be pigeon-holed into the defined theme of wholly withdrawing from the world, and instead should be determined through a reconfiguration of perceptual relations where the distinctions between subject and environment create instability.¹² Within these moments, vision juxtaposes the anchored, coherent spatial and temporal frameworks and metamorphoses into fragmentation, slowness, and discontinuity. Despite the fact that Ma grounds her work within film, her priority on perception being a changing and chaotic process establishes a critical perspective where sleep conditions can be perceived beyond a cinematic viewpoint.

Fundamentally, phenomenology plays a significant role in interpreting sleep disturbances within performance.¹³ Notions on perception as embodied and situated can be further established through the phenomenological framework of Maurice Merleau-Ponty, because perception, within his understanding, is a connected base in the lived body's engagement with the world.¹⁴ Meaning, the body is key to understanding how space is experienced, rather than merely as an object within the universe.¹⁵ In lieu of spatial experience, any type of disturbance to perception

¹¹ Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191.

¹² Giuseppe Barbato, "The Guardian of Dreams: The Neglected Relationship between Sleep and Psychoanalysis," *Brain Sciences* 15, no. 3 (2025): 281, <https://doi.org/10.3390/brainsci15030281>.

¹³ Phenomenology refers to a philosophical and research method centrally aimed at examining a primary accounts experience of structured consciousness. This qualitative approach analyzes the phenomenon of the "lived experience" where it is detached from biases (i.e., pre-notioned theories or assumptions), and maintains the grounded inquiry in regards to the meaning behind the experience.

¹⁴ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, "Phenomenology of Perception," *Philpapers.org*. 1945, <https://philpapers.org/rec/MERPOP-7>; David Michael Kleinberg-Levin, "Intercorporeality, Moral Self-Development and Openness to Alterity: On Merleau-Ponty's Redeeming of Childhood Experience," *Philosophies* 9, no. 5 (2024): 156, <https://doi.org/10.3390/philosophies9050156>.

¹⁵ Paolo Fusar-Poli and Giovanni Stanghellini, "Maurice Merleau-Ponty and the 'Embodied Subjectivity' (1908-61)," *Medical Anthropology Quarterly* 23, no. 2 (2009): 91-93, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25487868>.

necessitates a response within the body's relation to its environment. In the framework of disturbed sleep, this disturbance becomes evident because the body, while remaining physically present, has the capacity to act, orient, or respond in an altered manner, and thus produces a condition where perception is maintained without the stability of embodied agency.¹⁶

Even though phenomenology helps with a framework for understanding how such states are experienced, there is a danger of treating them as universal or as a simplified internal phenomenon. To add to Merleau-Ponty's theory, the work of Arthur Kleinman entangles his argument by highlighting how bodily experiences are configured by cultural and social contexts. Kleinman states that experiences of illness, pain, or altered states surpass biological events and are contextualized and given meaning through culturally specific frameworks. To clarify, the specificity that an individual feels in their body is not detached from how it is understood, articulated, and situated within an environment.

Collectively, these two approaches point out that disturbed states of perception, while most likely correlated with internal or physiological conditions, have a wider capacity for being understood through outside factors. While phenomenology, according to Merleau-Ponty, observes the immediacy of embodied experience, Kleinman emphasizes the conditions where these experiences are established and interpreted.¹⁷ In the context of this dissertation, this combined framework makes room for an analysis of disturbed sleep as being both experiential

¹⁶ David Michael Kleinberg-Levin, "Wallace Stevens' Poetic Realism: The Only Possible Redemption," in *Narrative and Ethical Understanding*, edited by Garry L. Hagberg (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2024), 295, doi.10.1007/978-3-031-58433-6_15; David M. Kleinberg-Levin, 2024. "Intercorporeality, Moral Self-Development and Openness to Alterity: On Merleau-Ponty's Redeeming of Childhood Experience," *Philosophies* 9, no. 5 (2024): 156, <https://doi.org/10.3390/philosophies9050156>.

¹⁷ Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.

and a constructed condition, one that emerges through bodily interaction, environment, and cultural events.¹⁸

Sleep is a universal, inescapable force that binds every living soul on this planet. The enigmatic realm of dreams, shrouded in mystery, entrances us all and pulses at the heart of our shared humanity. Through the lens of performance, dreams become more than fleeting images, igniting powerful emotions, provoking reflection, and stirring the depths of our subconscious. To understand how performances explore disturbed states of sleep is to appreciate their profound impact on the audience, immersing us in the haunting beauty and spectral wonder of the imagination. The interplay between spectral imagination and dream states not only influences viewers but also captivates them, leaving an indelible mark that lingers long after the performance ends. The dissertation, while only looking at the surface of sleep conditions, broadens the horizon for a new adaptation to how performance signifies and the important role of how sleep conditions are translated. The works of Yingmei Duan, Li Liao, Peng Wu, and Chen Wei will be discussed as case studies in the dissertation. These contemporary Sinophone artists maintain a theme of sleep disruption; however, they approach it in different ways in their works. Yingmei Duan and Li Liao address, in different methods, the spatial and temporal interplays in the context of sleep and the various modes that complicate its discourse. Peng Wu takes on sleep disturbance through a different lens, examining the body internally and externally from the environment. Wu collaborates with his audience and researchers in science and medicine with the knowledge pertaining to sleep conditions. While Wu has mentioned in interviews that he has

¹⁸ Arthur Kleinman's theory moves away from an institutional thinking of the biomedical framework and into examining illness and distress through a cultural framework. Kleinman's explanatory models shape how symptoms are perceived, narrated, and imbued with meaning in different social settings. In this study's analysis, the implementation of Kleinman's work examines how different Sinophone artists visualize and narrate the symptoms and sensations of disturbed states of sleep. Tracing how these representations are shaped and in turn contribute culturally are embedded explanatory models that have been centuries in the making. [Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.]

insomnia, his performance method surveys the many pressures of everyday life that are extended to the body. Furthermore, while Chen Wei uses photography to explore space and the tensions within that space, his art form becomes a performance in itself. This will further be discussed in Chapter 2. While both performance and photography construct disturbed perceptual states, they do so through fundamentally different phenomenological conditions. Performance unfolds through shared duration and embodied presence, whereas photography produces a suspended encounter in which perception is spatially constructed but temporally fixed. Wei's photographs function as staged, constructed events that operate performatively in their production of perceptual experience. Wei's artwork is important to this dissertation as it surveys sleep disturbances in relation to societal influence and the atmospheric tension that encompasses underlying pressures on individuals.

Chapter 1: Performing Disturbed States: Duration, Exposure, and the Public Body

Duration and Spatial Disruption in the Performances of Yingmei Duan

The introduction emphasizes the main themes as well as addresses the cultural and theoretical frameworks related to sleep disturbances. Chapter 1 focuses on the performance artist Yingmei Duan, whose work provides a foundation for viewing sleep disturbances in a realm of spatial and temporal constructs. While the focus is mostly on Duan's contribution, it would be remiss not to mention Li Liao's work, as it offers a new perspective on alternate realities and societal views relevant to collective experiences or sleep anomalies. Both Duan and Liao

approach narratives of liminal states in their performances, providing a critical lens for comparing and contrasting mediations of sleep disruption.¹⁹

Duan's performances coherently features a significant position within contemporary Sinophone art, as she fluidly visualizes the boundaries between sleep and wakefulness.²⁰ Her adaptations to sustained duration and minimal action shift the current understanding of the in-between toward a dissolution of boundaries, rendering the concept of liminality or thresholds into a physical entity of flesh, duration, and space. Her performances, such as in *Patience* (忍耐) (2004), operate through sustained duration and minimal action, producing conditions in which ordinary spatial and temporal structures are gradually unsettled (Figure 1). Duan's performance, *Patience* (忍耐) (2004), correlates with another one of her performances, *In Between* (之间) (2004), where she is trapped in a shelf and is unable to escape (Figure 1 and 2).²¹ These two live performances, *Patience* (忍耐) (2004) and *In Between* (之间) (2004), both performed at the Hochschule für Bildende Künste Braunschweig, similarly correlate with symptoms medically referred to as sleep paralysis, as this condition leaves the individual experiencing it trapped within their own body. In addition to immobilization, there is a further sense of being unsettled as the individual's mind is awake, and their inability to move creates the scary, overwhelming emotions of being unable to control anything within and outside their environment.

Duan's practice is deeply rooted in Sinophone contexts, drawing from the 1990s avant-garde Chinese performance art, traditions of bodily endurance, and experiences of rapid

¹⁹ The term liminality was discussed in the Introduction as it is relevant to the works of Yingmei Duan and Li Liao. Both artists play with the idea of liminality as a lens for examining the thresholds or in betweenness of specific states (sleep and wakefulness).

²⁰ Di-kai Chao, "Exploring Sinophone Liminality in Contemporary Chinese Fiction: Ghost Narratives and the Contouring of Invisible Realms," *Journal of the European Association for Chinese Studies* 6, no. 2 (2025): 158-179, <https://doi.org/10.25365/jeacs.2025.6.2>.

²¹ In the performance work, *Patience* (忍耐) (2004), Duan only is trapped within one shelf, and in the work, *In Between* (之间) (2004), Duan is lying between two shelves that are attached to the wall on display.

social change and displacement.²² Her engagement with liminality echoes broader Sinophone cultural patterns, negotiating tradition and modernity, authority and individual expression, and navigating boundaries shaped by migration, censorship, and social transformation.²³ It is crucial, essential in fact, to insist on a distinction that Duan's work makes impossible to ignore. The liminality she constructs is more than internal, subjective, or a private psychological state decorously projected outward through artistic gesture.²⁴ The construction of liminality emerges with fierce material specificity and force through the dynamic, irreducible interaction of body, time, and environment. Three elements that are each indispensable, each doing its own irreplaceable work, and none of which can be enveloped into the others without catastrophic loss. This is evident in *Patience* (忍耐) (2004), as Duan is embedded in a material construct, both metaphorically and physically, and cannot detach herself from the shelf on which she is positioned (Figure 1). The interplay with body, time, and environment is therefore essential as these themes engrain themselves into a more weighted analysis pertaining to understanding sleep disturbance in a different light. Additionally, from Victor Turner's perspective, liminal subjects are situated “betwixt and between”²⁵ socially defined positions.²⁶ Artists such as Duan spatialize this condition, transforming liminality into an environmental state. In her immersive

²² Gladys Pak Lei Chong, "The Corpse and Humanist Discourse: Dead Bodies in Contemporary Chinese Art," *China Information* 34, no. 1 (2020): 23, <https://doi.org/10.3390/arts12050217>.

²³ Xuan Wang, Kasper Juffermans, and Caixia Du, "Harmony as language policy in China: an Internet perspective," *Language Policy* 15 (2015), <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10993-015-9374-y>.

²⁴ Liminality has positioned itself within art history discourse as overextended, often serving as a phrase to explain anything ambiguous or “in-betweenness,” which is harmful if it is separated from its analytical specificity. Within the frame of art history and its scholarship, the use of liminality is often obscured and tends to neglect its processual nature, reducing it to a descriptive aesthetic or metaphor for ambiguity instead of a structural condition. The application of the term liminality is at risk of being diluted, through its new widely driven mobilization within art historical discourse.

²⁵ Victor Turner states, “Liminal entities are neither here nor there; they are betwixt and between the positions assigned and arrayed by law, custom, convention, and ceremonial.” Turner argues that liminal thresholds are states of in betweenness and can be seen within social structures of government and traditions. [Victor Turner, *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1969): 94-113.]

²⁶ Victor Turner, "Liminality and Communitas," in *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1969), 94-113; Jenny McGee, "Liminality and Art – Jenny McGee," The Liminality Project, 2022, <https://www.theliminalityproject.org/2022/01/20/1617/>.

installations, viewers are enveloped with constructed atmospheres that dissolve the boundaries between observer and environment, producing a condition of perceptual ambiguity akin to the disorientation found in Olafur Eliasson's *The Weather Project* (2003-2004) (Figure 3). Eliasson's immersive installation, displayed in the Tate Modern's Turbine Hall from 2003 to 2004, transformed the space into a vast social environment that felt like an illusion, as the lighting and overall atmosphere drew the audience into a confrontation between nature and the idea of a natural environment.²⁷ Here, within the performances of Duan, taking into account works such as Eliasson's interactive installation, liminality is devoid of experience as a passage between fixed identities and rather is an ongoing spatial condition in which the viewer remains suspended.²⁸ Together, these practices, evident in Duan and later observed in Liao's work, demonstrate how liminality in contemporary Sinophone art becomes spatially embedded, institutionally critical, and temporally sustained, challenging the processual and overall-resolving framework established by anthropological models.²⁹ Ironically, while Van Gennep and Turner stress

²⁷ Eliasson's *The Weather Project* (2003) was a ginormous and immersive installation exhibited in the Tate Modern's Turbine Hall. This large installation recreated the sun and the sky through mono-frequency lighting, haze machines, and mirrors. This series attracted over two million visitors, and as a result transformed the turbine hall into a social space where people used the space to lounge, which formed spaces into the ceiling.

²⁸ This shift in spatial suspension aligns with Michel Foucault's concept of heterotopia, wherein spaces simultaneously reflect and disrupt normative structures, rendering the gallery a site that is both real and unreal. Similarly, Li Liao expands liminality into the institutional and economic sphere, echoing the unbalanced gesture of Marcel Duchamp's *Fountain* (1917), in which the boundary between art and non-art is rendered indeterminate. [Ruth Dillon-Mansfield, "The Legacy of Duchamp's Fountain in the Philosophy of Art," Ruth-Dm.co.uk, 2023, <https://ruth-dm.co.uk/posts/what-is-art/>.] Liao's practice foregrounds the instability of value, labor, and authorship, positioning liminality as an epistemological condition that unsettles systems of meaning rather than experiential perception. [Michel Foucault, "Of Other Spaces (1967), Heterotopias." *Michel Foucault, Info*, 1967, <https://foucault.info/documents/heterotopia/foucault.heteroTopia.en/>.] In this context, Marc Augé's notion of "non-places" further emphasizes how contemporary art situates liminality within spaces of perpetual transition that resists resolution. Together, these practices demonstrate how liminality in contemporary art becomes spatially embedded, institutionally critical, and temporarily sustained, challenging the processual and overall resolving framework established by anthropological models. [Marc Augé, 1995. *Non-Places: An Introduction to Supermodernity*, (London: Verso Books, 1995).]

²⁹ Eva L. Hampel, *Liminal Speculations: Art, Nature and the Material Turn*, (Thesis, University of Wollongong, 2020), <https://hdl.handle.net/10779/uow.27665799.v1>; Radoslav Maglov, *Liminality in the Interpretations of the Corporeality in Contemporary Art*, (PhD. Thesis., National Academy of Art, 2022), 2-26, <https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.11519.38567>; Jenny McGee, "Liminality and Art," *The Liminality Project*, 2022. <https://www.theliminalityproject.org/2022/01/20/1617/>.

liminality's temporary nature, I argue it can be a more permanent condition.³⁰ Neither theorist fully accounts for sustained or autonomous liminal states, nor do they address institutional critique. Art transforms liminality from a social to a spatial condition and challenges institutional authority.³¹ Van Gennep and Turner's frameworks remain tied to linear time, individual subjects, and reintegration. However, in contemporary art, it extends liminality beyond these limits.³² In Duan's hands, liminality shifts from a figure of speech to a decorative application in art. Liminality is articulated as a material, temporally extended, viscerally felt condition that the performance itself produces and relentlessly sustains.

The altered states that arise in these performances are multifaceted in their depictions pertaining to sleep or unconsciousness. In alignment with Duan's practice of using her own body as instrument, site, and subject to explore temporal extension and audience participation, these depictions actively instantiate a threshold experience, making it happen. As Duan has stated in an interview, "What interests me is not just showing a boundary but making people step into it and

³⁰ Arnold van Gennep, *The Rites of Passage*, (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1909), 7-228; Victor Turner, "Liminality and Communitas," in *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1969), 94-113.

³¹ Originally theorized within anthropology, liminality emerges from a structured understanding of ritual transition. In *The Rites of Passage* (1909), Van Gennep defines rites of passage to have three phases. These phases being separation, limen, and aggregation, situate the liminal phase as a temporary in which the subject is suspended between fixed social identities. This "margin" is characterized by ambiguity, as individuals pass through a cultural realm that refrain from using defining attributes of their previous or future status. Building upon this framework, Victor Turner, in *The Ritual Process* (1969), expands liminality beyond a structural function, describing liminal subjects as "betwixt and between" established social positions and emphasizing the indeterminate, destabilizing qualities of this condition. Turner argues that liminality is a "realm of pure possibility" in which a conceptual shift takes place and enables its migration beyond ritual contexts. Through installations, immersive environments, and temporally disjunctive practices, artists mobilize liminality to disrupt conventional systems of perception and meaning, transforming it into a critical framework that challenges fixed boundaries and reconfigures the relationship between viewer, artwork, and environment. [Victor Turner, *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1969), 94-113.]

³² Victor Turner's "Liminality and Communitas" explores liminality as a socially and symbolically suspended interval in which people are stripped of rank and remade, thereby exposing tensions between structure and communitas. He notes liminality's association with danger and pollution, as liminal things defy categories and can be treated as threatening by social structures. Through durational actions, repetitive gestures, and the inscription of her body into public spaces, Duan unsettles distinctions between activity and passivity, awareness and detachment, presence and absence. Her performances move liminality beyond metaphor, producing a material, temporally extended, and viscerally felt condition that is sustained by the performance itself. [Victor Turner, "Liminality and Communitas," in *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1969), 94-113]

feel it in their own bodies. When I perform for hours, the audience and I are inside a new condition, a space between, where time almost stops." She further notes, "I am interested in endurance because it changes the body, the mind, and the relationship to the people watching. The performance is real labor, not a symbol, and when the body endures, a new reality appears for a moment, neither here nor there."³³ For Duan, this insistence on embodied liminality is impacted by the Sinophone cultural context and its complex, often anguished history of negotiation between individual expression and collective identity. Embodied liminality is further amplified by the legacy of Chinese performance art, which is one of engagement with discipline, endurance, and bodily transformation. Her work subtly and powerfully critiques the long-standing resonance of bodily endurance as a mode of resistance within Chinese art, a resonance shaped by the lived experience of rapid social change and the grinding pressures of both tradition and modernization.³⁴ As a Sinophone artist, Duan draws upon and unsettles these cultural frameworks, insisting that liminal experience is never neutral or innocent; regardless always conditioned by the histories and social worlds from which it emerges and to which it speaks.³⁵ This is a critical difference that cannot be overstated. Where representation maintains a safe, manageable distance between the work and its subject, Duan narrows that distance entirely and without mercy. The liminal condition is generated by the material conditions of the performance itself, by the actual duration endured, space inhabited, and body laboring in real time, in real space, before real eyes.³⁶ In Duan's work, the experience of temporal suspension and perceptual instability slowly crystallizes, inexorably, with the force of something inevitable, from

³³ Emily Stephenson, "Contemporary Chinese Performance Art: An Interview with Yingmei Duan," *The Courtauldian*, March 25, 2018, courtauldian.com.

³⁴ Jie Jiang, *The Conformed Body: Contemporary Art in China*, Modern Asian Art and Visual Culture (Leiden: Brill, 2024), 1-232.

³⁵ Michèle Ruo Yi Landolt, "The Sinophone Among Many Worlds," *ArtReview*, 2025, <https://artreview.com/the-sinophone-among-many-worlds/>.

³⁶ Arthur Kleinman and Peter Benson, "Culture, Moral Experience and Medicine," *Mount Sinai Journal of Medicine* 73, no. 6 (2006): 834-839, <https://doi.org/10.1002/j.1944-0678.2006.tb02004.x>.

the specific, irreducible configuration of performance, space, and duration that each work assembles.³⁷

Duan's performances, while stagnant, refuse narrative progression with a kind of ferocious, almost defiant, and quiet unfolding. This focus on duration resonates with certain pathways of international performance art, particularly in the work of artists such as Marina Abramović, Tehching Hsieh, and Vito Acconci.³⁸ For example, Abramović's iconic performance, *The Artist Is Present* (2010), draws on extended duration and repetition to dissolve boundaries between artist and audience (Figure 4). Abramović often amplifies endurance toward dramatic confrontation and catharsis. Taken together, Duan's approach is marked by a quieter, more insistently anti-climactic quality, depicted as a refusal of spectacle in favor of an enveloping, indistinct flow of time.³⁹ Duan's durational work, *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), creates a paradoxical condition that feels at once monumental and nearly invisible (Figure 5). Viewers are immersed in a formless temporal atmosphere rather than a singular dramatic event. The absence of a discernible beginning, middle, or end is not a structural deficiency; it becomes a precise and radical formal choice. Dismantling the viewer's deep-seated expectation that performance is a structured event with a destination, a payoff, or a release.⁴⁰ By regressing and examining the progression toward a climax or resolution, the work holds time open, stretching, thinning, and

³⁷ Another work that examines sleep constructs while also focusing on duration is Yingmei Duan's 14 day live performance, *Sleepless* (柏林无眠) (2007). Duan forces the audience to engage with themes related to the cycle of life and death. Within the 14 days at the BoulevART, Kunstherbst (Berlin, Germany), Duan changed the concept of the performative installation. The experience for the viewer is not only encountered through Duan's approach which invites them to play a part in the performance, but is further realized in photographic documents that are taken throughout the performance. [Yingmei Duan, *Sleepless* (柏林无眠), 2007, Live performance installation, Yingmei Duan Performance Art 段英梅行为艺术 (in working...), <https://www.yingmei-art.com/sleepless-2/>.]

³⁸ Delaney Brigid, "Tehching Hsieh, Extreme Performance Artist: 'I give you clues to the crime' | Brigid Delaney," *The Guardian*, Art and design section, October 24, 2017, <https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2017/oct/24/tehching-hsieh-extreme-performance-artist-i-give-you-clues-to-the>.

³⁹ Sotheby's Institute of Art, "Marina Abramović: Endurance and Evolution in Performance Art," *Sotheby's Insight*, 2025, <https://sothebysinstitute.com/articles/info-series-marina-abramovic/>.

⁴⁰ Katherine Araniello and Adrian Heathfield, "The Paradox of the Body," *Performance Research* 17, no. 2 (2012): 70.

pressing on it from all sides until it loses its directional quality entirely and becomes something formless and immense.

Rather than abandoning the original focus on liminality, this study seeks to re-specify the lexicon by examining how contemporary art, specifically within contemporary Sinophone art, evokes ambiguity and is retranslated into modes of spatial, temporal, and institutional conditions that originally defined in-between experiences. The performances of Duan use these modes of duration and muted action in order to emphasize its uncanniness. Instead of presenting discrete events, her project *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011) unfolds through repetitive gestures performed across a range of public environments, including urban streets and semi-public interiors (Figure 6). The defining and relentless characteristics of Duan's practice are her weaponization of duration. Rather than utilizing it as a formal experiment or aesthetic flourish, she creates a beating conceptual engine at the very heart of her work. For example, in *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), the durational performance-installation that has been presented within various museums and exhibitions around Europe and Asia, Duan repeatedly inserts herself into the raw fabric of everyday space, displaying urban streets thick with pedestrian noise and exhaust, architectural antechambers caught between function and forgetting, gallery rooms humming with the cold indifference of fluorescent light (Figure 5). Within this performance-installation piece, which is adapted to each specific exhibition space, Duan uses an atmosphere similar to a fairytale storybook setting that emits the feeling of being under the canopy in a forest. The soft and childlike environment enchants the viewers to enter and interact with her. Duan performs a dramatic persona of "happiness," engaging visitors through

conversation, gestures, and shared presence.⁴¹ Even though it initially appears whimsical, the performance maintains a sharper conceptual edge (Figure 7).

This visual intensity is where she undertakes prolonged, often aching minimal actions, such as a sustained posture held well past the point of dignity, a gesture repeated until it loses all legibility and becomes something stranger and more primal, a stillness so deliberate and so absolute that it becomes its own ferocious kind of labor. The actions in *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011) are simple, playful, and seemingly inconsequential, yet they extend beyond their expected duration, shifting attention away from what is being done toward how it is experienced viscerally over time (Figure 8). In doing so, Duan constructs conditions that parallel disturbed states associated with the threshold between waking and sleep, through the reconfiguration of perception within shared space.

A defining feature of *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011) is its insertion into everyday environments that lack a clear demarcation as performance (Figure 6). The figure of “Yingmei,” identifiable through a simple costume and exaggerated gestures, appears within spaces structured by routine movement and functional purpose. Opposite to transforming these environments through dramatic intervention, Duan introduces a subtle and persistent disruption. The body becomes a space of temporal friction, interrupting the flow of daily activity without halting it entirely. Passersby may initially register her presence as incidental or anomalous, yet the continuation of her actions destabilizes this interpretation, producing a gradual shift in how the environment is perceived.

⁴¹ Yingmei Duan was inspired by Oscar Wilde’s fairy tale *The Happy Prince* (1888). Wilde’s classic story centers around a statue prince, that is made of gold, who becomes friends with a bird. The statue and bird sacrifice themselves for others in both life and death. As a result they reveal the true meaning of happiness, showing how compassion and selflessness are the true values to obtain pure happiness. [Jürgen Bernhard Kuck, *Yingmei Duan: Performance and Performative Installation Art, 1995-2013*, edited by Jürgen Bernhard Kuck (Berlin, Germany, Lehmanns Media, 2014), 169.]

Within duration, the disruption is the main response, as actions are absorbed into the background of everyday life through standing, repeating a gesture, or maintaining a posture; these take on a different persona when sustained past the expected timeframe. Duan's performance leaves viewers' expectations for narrative progression or resolution unmet. The primary attention transfers towards the experience of waiting, observing, and enduring. Time becomes centered on persistence, producing a temporal structure in which moments elongate and distinctions between beginning and end become less transparently defined.

The impacts of this temporal extension are more than slow time and are associated with altering its qualitative experience. Repetition functions as a significant role in this process because of the repeated gestures. The initial intention becomes less legible, and the distinction between deliberate action and automatic movement dissolves. The body appears to continue acting; however, its direction or purpose is unclear. This condition recalls the altered states connected to disturbed sleep, in which awareness persists while agency is attenuated. Nonetheless, in Duan's work, this state is externalized and shared, produced through the interaction between body, duration, and environment.

From a phenomenological perspective, this destabilization of action can be understood through the framework of Maurice Merleau-Ponty, for whom perception is grounded in the body's capacity to orient itself in space through movement. In *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), this capacity is not removed and is instead rendered unstable (Figure 5). The persistence of minimal gesture disrupts the alignment between perception and action, producing a situation in which the body remains visible, yet not functioning as a reliable anchor for orientation. The viewer, encountering this changed condition within a shared environment, is brought into similar

uncertainty, as the usual cues that structure spatial and temporal experience become less dependable.⁴²

At the same time, it is difficult to fully understand the meaning of these conditions within the confines of embodied perception.⁴³ Within the constructs of Arthur Kleinman's critique, bodily experiences are formed by the social and cultural contexts in which they occur.⁴⁴ Duan's use of public space is essential in this matter, as her performances are allocated within environments governed by implicit norms regarding movement, behavior, and purpose. The persistence of her actions within these spaces produces a tension between what the space is intended for and what is occurring within it. This tension transforms how the performance is perceived, as viewers necessitate a negotiation between recognizing the work as art and interpreting it as part of everyday life.

While Duan herself has reflected on her deep interest in the ambiguity between states and the dissolution of fixed roles for both audience and performer, the theoretical viewpoint of Jean Ma links to this analysis, in which thresholds of perception and identity are articulated. My own interpretive extension, adopted by her critical lens, is that this temporal stretching aligns with the threshold condition in which the charged, unstable, electrically alive zone, where the boundaries between states of consciousness blur and identity begins, slowly and terrifyingly comes undone.⁴⁵ However, this understanding is not directly expressed in Ma's own critical writing or

⁴² From a phenomenological perspective, these sleep disturbances constitute nothing less than a violent disruption of embodied subjectivity at its most fundamental level, a rupture in the very structure through which we inhabit the world.

⁴³ Elizaveta Solomonova, "Sleep Paralysis: Phenomenology, Neurophysiology, and Treatment," in *The Oxford Handbook of Spontaneous Thought: Mind-Wandering, Creativity, and Dreaming*, edited by Kieran C. R. Fox and Kalina Christoff (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 441, <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/38694/chapter/336055798>.

⁴⁴ Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.

⁴⁵ Terms such as liminal zones or thresholds will be mentioned throughout this dissertation as they reference the boundaries between sleep and wakefulness as well as the concept of liminality. Liminality can be defined as an uncertain and troubling, transitional "in between" state of being eerily in limbo, where past identities or usual routines have become obsolete, however new ones haven't started. This term came from the Latin grammar, *limen*,

interviews.⁴⁶ Duan's performances induce a corresponding uncertainty that strikes the body before it reaches the mind, perceived in the gut and the skin before it is comprehended; her body exists in a space neither fully active nor completely at rest, suspended in an ambiguous, hovering state between intention and surrender.⁴⁷ The ambiguity established within the artistic experience is sustained and departs from resolution. The absence of a clear boundary between performance and non-performance creates a condition in which perception remains unsettled. The viewer is placed within an environment that feels both familiar and estranged, as the repetition of minimal actions invites a temporal density that contrasts with the transient nature of everyday movement. As a result of this interplay of duration, embodiment, and context, Duan's work constructs conditions in which perception becomes unstable, time is experienced as extended, and the body is seen as both active and constrained.⁴⁸ This imbalance in the body and perception is evident in her performance, *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), as well as her other works, such as *Patience* (忍耐) (2004) (Figure 5 and 1).

The decision not to directly depict disturbed sleep, *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), establishes analogous conditions through the manipulation of temporal and spatial relations.⁴⁹ The body, while continuously visible, retracts from a stable interpretation; the environment, while unchanged in its material form, is perceptually altered through the accumulation of time. In

meaning threshold and is characterized as an uncertain and disorienting phase that is also transformative within a transition period. This term is not only seen in historical contexts, but also within psychology, spirituality, and anthropology. [Jon Sutton, "Liminality and the Stuff of Life," *The British Psychological Society*, 2016, bps.org, <https://www.bps.org.uk/psychologist/liminality-and-stuff-life>.]

⁴⁶ Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191.

⁴⁷ Giuseppe Barbato, "The Guardian of Dreams: The Neglected Relationship Between Sleep and Psychoanalysis," *Brain Sciences* 15, no. 3 (2025): 281, <https://doi.org/10.3390/brainsci15030281>.

⁴⁸ Emily Stephenson, "Contemporary Chinese Performance Art: An Interview with Yingmei Duan," *The Courtauldian*, March 25, 2018, courtauldian.com; "Yingmei Duan," Studio Plesungan, studioplesungan.org.

⁴⁹ Connie Choi, "Human Instincts and Societal Conventions: The Performance Art of Yingmei Duan," *Journal of Contemporary Chinese Art* 5, no. 1 (2018).

this regard, Duan demonstrates how changed states associated with sleep can be constructed externally, within collective spaces, through performance.

Stillness, Exposure, and the Public Body in Urban Environments of Li Liao

Yingmei Duan produces disturbed states in performance through duration and repetition, whereas Li Liao adopts a different approach, focusing on modes of stillness and exposure. In Li Liao's performative piece, *Sleeping Bed 01 (Optics Valley)* (单人床 01 (光谷)) (2011), the artist places his own body within urban environments to appear to be asleep, lying, or resting in locations that are abnormal (Figures 9 and 10).⁵⁰ This display, in which his sleeping body is presented in a public space, creates an immediate tension between private and public, control and vulnerability, and activity and passivity.

The body in *Sleeping Bed 01 (Optics Valley)* (单人床 01 (光谷)) (2011) is represented by decreased movement. In contrast to Duan's sustained gestures, Liao's performance depicts a figure that appears inactive, withdrawn from purposeful engagement. However, this stillness is not conventionally characterized as rest. The underlying intent of situating this within the public, and being exposed and often transient, undermines the possibility of genuine sleep. The body exists in a suspended state, observed as neither wholly asleep nor entirely engaged with its surroundings.

This type of ambiguity forms a key outline to the performance's effectiveness. Passersby encountering the scene are forced to negotiate how it's interpreted. Whether it is a performance, accident, or social disturbance, it is left in the viewer's court. The detachment of a distinct marker

⁵⁰ The *Sleeping in the Streets* (2011) series is performed in a public space by the artist Li Liao. Liao used a mattress and placed it within an open space on the ground. Liao would then sleep until he would wake up naturally or by unexpected interruption. This performance project was carried out four times, such as on an intersection on Guanggu Pedestrian Street, inside an ATM room, next to Meadow Lake, and in a playground. [White Space Beijing, 2015. “李燎 | Li Liao 2010 - 2015,” cdn.videotage.org, 2015, https://cdn.videotage.org.hk/wp-content/uploads/2022/12/08174404/Li-Liao_2010-2015.pdf.]

for which artistic framing functions is intensified through its uncertainty. The observer is placed in an atmosphere that does not have a fixed interpretation, and thus it creates a perceptual condition that mirrors the ambiguity of disturbed sleep states, in which the distinction between awareness and unawareness is fragmented and impaired.

Crucially, the spatial dimension within this work maintains an important skeleton, as public space is structured by the expectations of movement, visibility, and behavior. Liao's action of lying down in the street interrupts these expectations, shining a light on the behavioral disjunction that reshapes the environment. The body serves two different functions, as both object and obstruction, shifting the flow of movement and calling attention to the norms that govern spatial use. Rather than a gradual disruption, there is an immediate upheaval that is more acutely distinct from Duan's work, where transformation accumulates over time.⁵¹

Examining Liao's work from a phenomenological viewpoint, the apparent immobility of the body accounts for conditions in which perception persists without the capacity for action. Contrastingly, within Duan's work, this state is not depicted as an internal experience and is one that operates through spatial arrangement.⁵² The body's vulnerability surfaces through its placement in the environment rather than as an inheritance within the body.

⁵¹ As Maurice Merleau-Ponty argues, "the body is our general medium for having a world." In *Sleeping in the Streets*, this "medium" fails, splits, or becomes obstructed. Merleau-Ponty's argument formulates the body to function as a transparent structure through which perception and action are oriented. However, in Liao's *Sleeping in the Streets* project, this mediating function is disrupted. The body becomes divided between two unstable roles in which it is an object within the field of vision and an obstruction to its own agency. Positioned horizontally within the urban environment, producing a condition in which the body is neither passive nor objectified, but stuck in a state that is both exposed and restricted. On this note, the performance does not represent a disturbance state, but constructs one through the breakdown of the body's role as a stable perceptual medium. [Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, translated by Colin Smith (London: Routledge, 1962), page 169.]

⁵² David Michael Kleinberg-Levin, "Wallace Stevens' Poetic Realism: The Only Possible Redemption," in *Narrative and Ethical Understanding*, edited by Garry L. Hagberg (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2024), 295, doi.10.1007/978-3-031-58433-6_15; David M. Kleinberg-Levin, "Intercorporeality, Moral Self-Development and Openness to Alterity: On Merleau-Ponty's Redeeming of Childhood Experience," *Philosophies* 9, no.5 (2024): 156, <https://doi.org/10.3390/philosophies9050156>.

Arthur Kleinman's work opens a pathway for examining the meaning of the sleeping body being sculpted by the social and cultural frameworks that systematize public space.⁵³ Sleeping in the streets maintains a negative narrative within society as this action is typically associated with marginality, precarity, or displacement. Liao's performance interacts with these constructs and, in doing so, creates a more complex perspective for the audience on how their perception of the body is used as both subject and object. Meaning, the performance does not just show a sleeping figure; the figure is the epicenter for networking social meanings, which form how it is perceived.⁵⁴

The comparison of Yingmei Duan's performances, such as *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), with Liao's *Sleeping Bed 01 (Optics Valley)* (单人床 01 (光谷)) (2011), lays out a structural framework for how modes of stillness and exposure create an important position in

⁵³ Applied to sleep disturbances, Kleinman's insight is nothing less than revelatory, meaning the presence felt during an episode is different from some universal neurological residue, cold and impersonal, drifting through the dark without origin or meaning. Sleep disturbances position themselves as actively shaped by culturally available narratives, by ghosts, spirits, and ancestral forces that have haunted the collective imagination for generations. Narratives that reach into the body's deepest terror and give it form, a face, and a name. [Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.]

⁵⁴ Examining Li Liao's work through liminality, being at the heart of society (i.e., such as in labor processes), which can be seen in Li Liao's performance *Consumption*, 2012, Performance documentation: ready-made materials (uniform, identity card, labor contract, iPad mini), [New Museum, New York. Source: <https://www.artsy.net/artwork/li-liao-consumption>.] opens up profound questions for broader debates about agency, subjectivity, and labor politics. By demonstrating how systems of repetition and control generate bodily thresholds, Li Liao's practice implicates the worker, the wider social body, consumers, organizations, and the policies that enable these systems to persist. His work suggests that the crisis of agency within contemporary labor is not an isolated phenomenon but symptomatic of structural conditions that erode individuality and diminish possibilities for resistance or self-realization. In this sense, Liao's analysis of liminality challenges us to reconsider the stakes of labor politics, urging a move beyond economic calculation toward an engaged understanding of the affective and existential costs of modern work. The recognition that subjectivity can be systematically undermined by repetitive labor practices foregrounds urgent questions of collective responsibility, rights, and the need for new imaginaries of agency in the face of accelerating automation and mechanization. His work, such as *Consumption* (2012) suggests that the crisis of agency within contemporary labor is not an isolated phenomenon but symptomatic of structural conditions that erode individuality and diminish possibilities for resistance or self-realization. In this sense, Liao's analysis of liminality challenges us to reconsider the stakes of labor politics, urging a move beyond economic calculation toward an engaged understanding of the affective and existential costs of modern work. The recognition that subjectivity can be systematically undermined by repetitive labor practices foregrounds urgent questions of collective responsibility, rights, and the need for new imaginaries of agency in the face of accelerating automation and mechanization. [Li Liao, *Consumption*, 2012, Performance documentation, New York. Source: <https://www.artsy.net/artwork/li-liao-consumption>.]

representing sleep disturbances (Figures 5 - 10). Instead of utilizing repetition and subtle disruption, both practices by these two artists offer a meaningful analysis of conditions in which the relationship between the body, space, and perception constitutes instability rather than resolution for the viewer.⁵⁵ Duan achieves this through duration and the gradual erosion of temporal expectations, and Liao, through his approach, achieves this embodied imbalance through the immediate disjunction created by the placement of the sleeping body in a public atmosphere. Taken together, both case studies produce narratives of disturbed states through the manipulation of spatial and temporal conditions.

Chapter 2: Mediated Disturbance: Environment and Perceptual Disorientation

Performativity of Bodily Constraint and Endurance by Peng Wu

The introduction gives a grounding for the main themes and the cultural and theoretical frameworks. Chapter 1 brings into play the beginning case studies, examining how disturbed states emerge through constructing the body within public space. Chapter 2 will examine the work of Peng Wu, who shifts the spotlight towards the limits of the body itself. His performances often correlate with conditions of physical constraint or endurance, in which the body is subjected to continued pressure, restriction, or repetitive strain. Within these conditions, Wu creates states in which the body is visually caught between control and collapse, thus establishing a framework of perceptual tension that resonates with disturbed sleep and its shifting states.

Peng Wu's performances confront the demanding constraints of enduring repetitive experiences over a long period of time. For example, *Archive of Sleeplessness* (2019), which is

⁵⁵ Despina Zacharopoulou, "Being Surface," *Performance Philosophy* 7, no. 2 (2022): 111-140, <https://doi.org/10.21476/PP.2022.72360>.

part of a sleep study project where collectively Wu, medical professionals, and the public exchange knowledge of sleep and healing, eliminating themes of individual identity, such as patient and doctor (Figure 11).⁵⁶ Examining insomnia, without prejudice to the patient's identity in the study, challenges institutional authority and mechanical healing. The narrative within this performance questions the role of imperfect individuals and components and their relationship with society, symbolically being the machine, and how society continues running every day. The machine is what Wu is questioning as a key factor in what is harmful to individual beings. These performance spaces, which Wu uses, maintain minimal action, allowing the audience's attention to remain focused on the body and its relation to the imposed condition. Unlike Duan's performances, where she brings together everyday environments, Wu's basis lies in the body being a space of pressure, and as a result, highlights the limits of endurance instead of maintaining the atmosphere as a disruption of social space.

On this note, the temporal building blocks of Wu's performances are articulated through endurance. To clarify even further, the extended duration emphasizes the viewers' raised awareness of the strains that are placed on the body. Tiny alterations in posture or movement increase the heightened weight, as they identify the ongoing negotiation between control and fatigue. Time is experienced as accumulation, instead of being a progression, and it is measured through the persistence of effort, as opposed to an unfolding of events.

This intensified stress on endurance forms a critical perspective on perceptual engagement. The audience is transcended into a state of sustained attention, where the condition of the body becomes the main attraction. This is evident in Wu's collaborative work with Dr.

⁵⁶ Melanie Pankau, *Many Ways of Making Home: A conversation with the 2022/23 MCAD–Jerome Fellow on creating participatory spaces for collective struggle and shifting from studio practice to dinner table practice*, (Interview, Mn Artists: Arts Writing From Mn, Beyond Mn, 2023), <https://mnartists.walkerart.org/peng-wu-many-ways-of-making-home>.

Michael Howell, a neurologist and sleep researcher. In *Daydream Chapel* (2019), the individual's body is used as the center stage (Figure 12).⁵⁷ This performative piece engages the participants to lie down beside a stranger and have a conversation with them. Wu's installation, with a strong emphasis on spiritual and sacred experiences, critiques how society's restlessness and disquiet affect each individual and, consequently, harm the individual's basic need for rest and relaxation. It is my belief, and according to Wu, that by continually going every day without a way to calm down and give your body time to decompress, many individuals become detached from themselves, and, as a result, there is continued pressure on the body. Additionally, implicating an absence of narrative or resolution changes the overall encompassing deliberation toward the experience of waiting and observing, metamorphosing a tension that is both physical and temporal. This tension can create an increased awareness of one's own bodily state, as the viewer becomes attuned to the demand and vulnerability of the performer.

To understand sleep disturbances as a cultural experience, one must first understand sleep as something far stranger and more philosophically charged than the cessation of wakefulness. It is here that the work of Jean Ma becomes indispensable. In her landmark study, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (2022), Ma compellingly argues against the long tradition of treating sleep as a simple absence, as a negation of consciousness, and as a passive withdrawal from the world of thought and action.⁵⁸ From Plato through Descartes to Freud, sleep has often been portrayed as the antithesis of self-mastery, representing a regression into an ungovernable or diminished state.⁵⁹ Ma, however, challenges this tradition by advancing a

⁵⁷ Weisman Art Museum, "Conversations about Sleep with Peng Wu and Dr. Michael Howell | Weisman Art Museum," University Of Minnesota, 2026, <https://wam.umn.edu/conversations-about-sleep-peng-wu-and-dr-michael-howell>.

⁵⁸ Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191.

⁵⁹ Jennifer M. Windt, "Dreams and Dreaming," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2025. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/dreams-dreaming/>.

perspective in which sleep is conceived as a positive, generative, and fundamentally liminal condition. Meaning, her viewpoint positions sleep as being a threshold state that is not confined to being a passive entity.⁶⁰ Sleep in Ma's vision is a suspended experience that transforms, opening the sleeper onto new modes of relation, perception, and being-in-the-world. For Ma, sleep designates ways of existing in the world, in relation to people, places, and the past, ways that waking life precludes or refuses to acknowledge. Apart from an interruption of subjectivity, its existence is an extension of it into unfamiliar territory, a territory without the clean borders of consciousness and will. This understanding is critical for the present study because sleep disruption occurs precisely at the threshold Ma describes, at the edges of sleep.

Ma's framework, developed in dialogue with thinkers such as Maurice Merleau-Ponty and Jean-Luc Nancy, contends that the liminal state of sleep is not classified as only psychological, and it further spans as a meticulously rooted bodily experience and intersubjectivity.⁶¹ Sleep operates as a mode of existence that connects the sleeper to others in terms of environments, histories, and beliefs that continue to exert influence in the absence of waking consciousness.⁶² By applying Ma's framework on the liminal state of sleep to the phenomenon of guǐ yā shēn (鬼压床), this insight is revelatory.⁶³ The ghost that presses down

⁶⁰ Giuseppe Barbato, "The Guardian of Dreams: The Neglected Relationship Between Sleep and Psychoanalysis," *Brain Sciences* 15, no. 3 (2025): 281, <https://doi.org/10.3390/brainsci15030281>; Thomas Fuchs, "The Phenomenology of Habit and Embodiment in Merleau-Ponty," *Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences* 11, no. 1 (2012): 849-869; Patricia Moya, "Habit and Embodiment in Merleau-Ponty," *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience* 8, no. 92324 (2014), <https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2014.00542>; Maurice Merleau-Ponty, "Phenomenology of Perception, 1962," *Phenomenology of Perception*, (London: Routledge, 1945).

⁶¹ Jean-Luc Nancy was a French philosopher who explored themes of liminal states and bodily experiences. He was the Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel Chair and a professor of philosophy at The European Graduate School (EGS). Some of his works on liminal states and exploring the body are *Corpus* [Jean-Luc Nancy, *Corpus*, (Fordham University Press, 2008), edited by Richard A Rand, and John D Caputo, <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt13x04c6>.], *The Ground of the Image* [Nancy, Jean-Luc, "The Ground of the Image," *Perspectives in Continental Philosophy*, 2009, <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt13x06f6>.], and *The Philosophy of Touch*. [Jacques Derrida, *On Touching, Jean-Luc Nancy*. (Interview, Stanford, California: Stanford University Press, 2005).]

⁶² Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191.

⁶³ Xingyu Chen, "Spirit during sleep," *USC Digital Folklore Archives*, 2017, <https://folklore.usc.edu/spirit-during-sleep/>.

upon the sleeping body does not arrive from nowhere; it arrives from a specific cultural inheritance, from generations of belief that have shaped what the sleeping body is prepared to encounter, what it is prepared to feel, and what it is prepared to name. The liminal condition of sleep, far from emptying the sleeper of cultural meaning, renders them exquisitely, terrifyingly open to it.

From a phenomenological standpoint of Merleau-Ponty, the body functions as the initial location through which the world is perceived and navigated. Wu's work can be seen through this lens, where the performance's function is destabilized. The imposed burdens disrupt the body's capacity to act of freewill, situating a condition in which perception persists; however, agency is limited.⁶⁴ Even though the body stays visibly present, the ability to orient itself within space is compromised, thus producing a situation in which perception becomes gradually uncertain.⁶⁵

Furthermore, this condition mirrors the experience of being trapped in a state of forced stillness, where awareness persists despite restricted movement.⁶⁶ In retrospect, the intention to disregard representing such a state, Wu positions the narrative through a more physical entity,

⁶⁴ In the endurance-based performances of Peng Wu, the body's role as a stable perceptual medium is further destabilized through the intensification of physical constraint. As Maurice Merleau-Ponty discusses, the body ordinarily functions as "our general medium for having a world," enabling orientation, movement, and action. In Wu's work, this mediating function begins to break down under sustained pressure. The body is subjected to conditions that test its limits, through stillness, repetition, or spatial confinement, producing a state in which movement is labored and contingent. Merleau-Ponty notes that we are able to "recognize the visual representation of what is invisible to us in our own body," indicating that bodily perception exceeds direct visual access. In Wu's performances, this relationship is strained and the body becomes an object of heightened awareness, its limits registered through tension, fatigue, and constraint. At the same time, the performer's experience of the body remains partially inaccessible to the viewer, producing a division between the body as seen and the body as lived. This split reinforces the body's dual function as both object and obstruction. The body is visible as a physical entity under stress and resistant to full perceptual access. [Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, translated by Colin Smith (London: Routledge, 1962), 169 & 172-173.]

⁶⁵ Myrtani Tsikandilakis, "From Subliminality, to the Unconscious Mind: Philosophical Lineages, Evolutionary Paradoxes, and the Future of the Origins of the Unconscious," *Philosophical Psychology* 60, no. 2 (2026): 27, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12124-026-09974-3>.

⁶⁶ Michèle Ruo Yi Landolt, "The Sinophone Among Many Worlds," *ArtReview*, 2025, <https://artreview.com/the-sinophone-among-many-worlds/>.

using limitation and endurance in order to create a situation in which the body is depicted as suspended between action and immobility. The viewer, witnessing this sustained tension, is attracted towards and brought into a similar condition or perceptual unease.

Staged Nocturnal Environments in the Photography of Chen Wei

The examination of Peng Wu's performative works, set within institutional walls, brings to focus the spatial and societal tensions that weigh on individuals in their everyday lives. The interplay between public and private experiences that Wu plays upon sheds new light on how sleep becomes a newfound mode through which the body attempts to articulate itself to the individual. Peng Wu's performances concentrate centrally on the constrained body, where Chen Wei's practice repositions perceptual instability to the environment itself. Chen Wei's staged photographic interiors, typically characterized by artificial lighting and the dearth of human figures, establish environments that depict suspended states of temporal and spatial ambiguity. The artist takes away a direct approach towards displaying disturbed sleep; however, he manufactures conditions that evoke its perceptual qualities. As a result of comparing Wu's depiction of the normative environment in an institutional setting with Wei's spatial imagery of artificiality, a broader analysis emerges of the constraints on the body and environment that manifest in sleep.

Even though Chen Wei's practice is most often categorized within photography, the constructed nature of his images pulses with the spirit of performance. His environments are not discovered by chance, but carefully conjured into being, each scene meticulously staged, every object and shaft of light deliberately chosen and placed to weave an atmosphere thick with

intention.⁶⁷ Here, the photograph transcends documentation, becoming the vivid record of a creative ritual in which space is shaped and brought to life. The absence of the human figure does not diminish this sense of performativity; instead, it magnifies the energy coursing through the inanimate. The “action” of Wei’s work erupts in the choreography of objects and illumination, the dramatic interplay of light and shadow, the lush calibration of color, and the intricate dance of spatial relations, all of which merge to conjure a singular, immersive perceptual experience. This framing is vital for understanding how Wei’s work constructs disturbed perceptual states. Unlike live performance, in which duration unfolds in real time, Wei’s visual scenes compress this process into a single, suspended moment. Yet the photograph retains the trace of its construction, inviting the viewer to engage with it as a dynamic representation, a residue of an event. The viewer’s perception is guided through the image in a manner that parallels the temporal unfolding of performance, in which attention shifts across surfaces, lighting conditions, and spatial ambiguities, producing a delayed and unsettled mode of viewing. In this sense, the photograph functions as a performative space, staging and sustaining perceptual disorientation in the absence of a live body. For example, Wei’s photograph, *Noon Insomnia* (2007), while this particular work does not use neon lighting and features a human figure, which is different from his other works, the photography still evokes spatial and unreal qualities that extend into a moving-image realm (Figure 13). The visual depiction in *Noon Insomnia* (2007) utilizes Wei’s idiosyncratic aesthetic in order to confront the Kafkaesque

⁶⁷ Chen Wei is known as a multimedia artist that builds detailed, surrealist sets. His strategically staged photographs act as a film that doesn’t exist, where he uses performers, occasionally, and props to evoke ambiguous and melancholic experiences. There are various other Sinophone artists who use narratives of performance and insert these ideals into a photographic scene. For example, the contemporary artist, Chi Peng, who digitally manipulates himself into theatrical scenarios. [“Chi Peng | Whitestone Gallery,” 2018. Whitestone Gallery, 2018, <https://www.whitestone-gallery.com/blogs/artist/chi-peng?srsId=AfmBOooyKGiLNIYIPDO0WEcfGsWWzgJftPbIj3xX5RhO5QP7yaJnRJ>.] Another example being the artist Zhang Huan, who stages performances and specifically tailors them for the camera. [Zhang Huan, “Zhang Huan English Website,” Zhanghuan.com, 2019, http://www.zhanghuan.com/index_en.aspx.]

paradox.⁶⁸ Going on an adventure that ultimately leads nowhere becomes symbolic of fighting a war against the bureaucracy in China, which ends in no resolution.⁶⁹ The photograph depicts a person sinking in a boat, which is aimed towards the other side of the water.⁷⁰ The symbolic nature and performative lens of this photograph examine how forced labor on the body, the environment, and continual pressures manifest into sleep disturbances. The title of this work further emphasizes this nature. Understanding Chen Wei's practice in these terms reinforces the broader argument of this dissertation.⁷¹ If disturbed states associated with sleep are not represented and instead are produced, then Wei's work demonstrates how such production can occur through the construction of space alone. The photograph becomes more than an image of an environment, and instead becomes an active site in which perceptual instability is generated, extending the logic of performance beyond the live body into the domain of the image.

Wei's visual depictions usually present interiors that are radiant by the use of neon or artificial light, in which objects are deliberately arranged, yet the rationality is ambiguous. The

⁶⁸ This term is derived from Franz Kafka, who was a writer and novelist known for his surreal and dreamlike narratives. A Kafkaesque paradox is a scenario, one of nightmarish and illogical encompassment, where the individual is confined to a surreal, incomprehensible bureaucracy, engaging in a combat that is both necessary and impossible to win. A duality with absurdity and powerlessness are experienced and felt within this paradox and the attempt for clarity or justice is not resolved. [Martin Boszorád, "On the Cultural Virality of Truth in Kafka and the Kafkaesque." *Critical Stages/Scènes Critiques*, November 19, 2024,

[https://www.critical-stages.org/30/on-the-cultural-virality-of-truth-in-kafka-and-the-kafkaesque/.](https://www.critical-stages.org/30/on-the-cultural-virality-of-truth-in-kafka-and-the-kafkaesque/)]

⁶⁹ Chen Wei is reacting to the conditions in China in which there is continual rapid development and fast urbanization. Wei uses a more subtle approach in his works that confront how this whirlwind of development is problematic. The title, *Noon Insomnia* (2007) references Wei's village from his upbringing in the 80s. In OTA Fine Arts overview of Wei, it is mentioned how the artist would go outside in the afternoon when everyone including factory workers would go home and nap. Looking back at this, the chaotic changes to rest and labor throughout the years is being questioned by Wei as well as questions to the endgame and purpose from this new form of urbanization. Wei's essay *Thoughts on Fasting* (2012), discusses the absurdity and confinements of the Chinese security apparatus. Emphasizing the hierarchical structures of government and surveillance methods is harmful to the freedom of China's citizens. [Chen Wei, "Thoughts on Fasting." *Index on Censorship* 41, no.1 (2012): 107–12, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0306422012438818>.]

⁷⁰ OTA Fine Arts, "Chen Wei: Noon Insomnia, Singapore, 3 July - 15 August, 2015," <https://www.otafinearts.com/exhibitions/95-chen-wei-noon-insomnia-chen-wei/>.

⁷¹ Topics of forced labor can be further compared and contrasted to Li Liao and Peng Wu's performances. A deeper analysis of forced labor can be studied between these artist's emphasis on labour and the body. This dissertation however does not fully dive into this narrative, as it will further complicate the central argument of this study. In that labor in these works do correlate with sleep, however labor narratives bring in many new themes that have to be broken down and further analyzed. Forced labor on society is an important topic to be discussed within these works.

absence of a visible individual escalates the experience of dislocation, as the observer is permitted to view a space that is coherently inhabited and empty. This motion of ambiguity interrupts the observer's ability to fully understand the scene within a categorically lucid temporal and narrative framework, and as a result, an environment of perceptual uncertainty is created. For example, in *Front Door Nail* (2024), Wei depicts a scene, with a purposeful use of lighting, that highlights a sense of entrapment that individuals experience when they are in situations of being controlled (Figure 14). Each part of the photograph is intentional, as the different lights and materials, or their lack thereof, hold meaning and serve as iconographic motifs. The limitations of lighting in this work paradoxically create a block, taking away the sense of hope that permeates the dim room. The light coming from the barely opened door brings the outside world into play, yet the central lightbulb serves as a blockage, forcing a tension of uneasiness to be able to open the door, creating a sense of isolation. Wei, who is interested in themes of rapid development and transformation in China's bustling cities, articulates a new narrative of the in-between and maintains a confused discourse for its witnesses.

Within Wei's photographs, there is an artificiality that encompasses the depicted environments, serving effectively to underscore the central themes. Juxtaposed with documentary photography, which necessitates capturing existing conditions, Wei's art form fabricates spaces that are strategically staged yet lack formal interpretation. The lighting, composition, and arrangement of objects imbue the space with a surreal, unilateral quality, as though the audience is looking at a scene not within the normal temporal flow. The future becomes unclear in the mode of time suspension, forming an incomprehensible, indistinguishable condition among past, present, and future. Other works by Wei, such as *Light of Folding Bed* (2009) and the *Slumber Song* (2014) series, also utilize space in an ambiguous,

bright aesthetic to create a time suspension that lacks a clear interpretation (Figures 15 and 16).⁷² An emphasis on nostalgia dilutes the temporal framing of these staged works. The illogical depiction in these two works maintains an atmospheric quality in its sleep imagery. The photograph, *Light of Folding Bed* (2009), displaying a bedframe in a mysterious space, creates a duality between the lighting and materials, in which the fragmented metal objects on the bedframe, while sharp in appearance, transcend the lighting to reach various spots in the space. There is no distinguishable vantage point to determine where the tensions are in the boundaries of Wei's spatial and temporal framing. This emphasis of pressure and constraint within space and time is similarly alluded to in the *Slumber Song* (2014) series and in *Front Door Nail* (2024). The absence of a formal or normative aesthetic maintains the unfamiliarity of sleep and the realms in which sleep impacts the world.

Importantly, Jean Ma's understanding of the edges of sleep is relevant and useful to this case study. Ma's critiques of sleep-related perception underscore the instability of vision at the threshold between waking and dreaming, where visual scenes are observed as fragmented, delayed, or detached from coherent spatial frameworks. Wei's photographs enforce a similar condition, in which the viewer's perception is unstable because of the lack of apparent orientation or narrative. The environment, while being seen as legible in its details, is wholly formatted to thwart comprehension.

⁷² Chen Wei, *Light of Folding Bed* (2009) presents a metal bed frame against a yellowish and neural dual toned wall. Lying on top of the bed frame appear to be metallic objects which create a disco lighting aesthetic within the space (Figure 15). The metallic objects on the bed frame appear sharp and rigid but are also shiny and pop out of the image. Underneath the frame on the floor, which has a shadow of the frame, there appears to be tiny shards of glass, that are almost like dust, which could bring that assumption that the metal objects on the bed frame are possible pieces of glass or mirrors that have been broken and fragmented. Wei's series, *Slumber Song* (2014), stages an atmosphere related to themes of sleep, dreams, and the nightlife of urban China that manifest into nostalgia (Figure 16).

Comparative Conditions: Between Body and Environment

Even though Peng Wu and Chen Wei's approaches to performance are distinctly different, taken together, they demonstrate that both relate to the construction of disturbed perceptual states. Wu offers an outlook for generating these conditions through the physical limits of the body, using constraint and endurance to elicit a tension between modes of control and immobility. On the other hand, Wei, in a different manner, repositions this instability to the environment, producing spaces that are apparently detached from a stable temporal and perceptual framework. For example, where Wu's *Archive of Sleeplessness* (2019) is crucially different in this sense from Wei's *Front Door Nail* (2024), Wu invites a more interactive approach that forces the viewer to realize their own limitations and outside burdens (Figures 11 and 14). However, Wei resists a resolution and makes the viewer come to their own terms with what is presented to them. The engagement between their two mediums produces a different reaction and interpretation for the audience, and their responses to the works are obviously dissimilar.

Wu's performances underscore how the viewer's confrontation with a body under sustained pressure diminishes the viewer's capacity for action, which gradually grows. The work of Wei, frequently takes away human figures, leaving a void where there should be a body or central focus. As a result of this absence, an equally disorienting condition is produced, in which the space alone constitutes an experience of unstableness and estrangement. Despite these differences, both practices alter the focus away from representation and into the creation of experience, illustrating how disturbed states connected with sleep can be made through the manipulation of space, time, and perception.

Peng Wu's performances contrast Wei's artwork, because Wei refuses any type of involvement of duration. Instead, it produces a sense of temporal suspension within a single photograph. The audience is encouraged to linger and search for meaning within the arrangement of objects, except that while searching extensively, becomes frustrated because of the absence of a gifted resolution. The conclusion gathered from this is a form of perceptual engagement that parallels the experience of being awake within a dream-like environment, where familiar elements are seen, yet do not cohere into a stable whole.

Conclusion

Rather than examining the outsets between sleep and waking as representative subjects, this study demonstrates how contemporary Sinophone artists actively inhabit and construct this ambiguous state through artistic practice as a constructed condition. To ensure both depth and breadth, the selection of artists Yingmei Duan, Li Liao, Peng Wu, and Chen Wei was guided by their distinct engagement with sleep anomalies in contemporary Sinophone art, as well as by their representation of the key mediums, including performance and photography.⁷³ Examined through these mediums, they demonstrate that sleep disturbances, such as sleep paralysis and insomnia, unlike a purely internal or psychological state, are a dynamic and materially grounded experience shaped by the interaction of body, time, and environment.⁷⁴ Although there are many known sleeping conditions and, in a Sinophone language, various terms used in folkloric as well as spiritual contexts, this dissertation cannot survey all the many sleeping anomalies. In this regard, this dissertation examines sleep disturbances in a broader context through the work of

⁷³ Eleanor Stephenson, "Contemporary Chinese Performance Art: An Interview with Yingmei Duan." *The Courtauldian*, 2018.

⁷⁴ Rossella Ferrari, *Performance and Postsocialism in Postmillennial China*, Cambridge Elements in Performance and Postmillennial China (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022), 42, <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009020190.004>.

specific artists who employ a performative approach. A comprehensive study of each sleeping disorder is not appropriate for the central theme and scope of this study. This dissertation has examined how contemporary Sinophone artists construct disturbed states associated with sleep through the guise of performance, duration, and spatial intervention. Rather than approaching sleep as a subject characterized iconographically, the works discussed throughout these chapters offer a different analysis for generating conditions that destabilize perception, bodily orientation, and temporal awareness. For this reason, these case studies transform the overall awareness away from symbolic depictions of dreaming or unconsciousness toward the experiential frameworks through which changed states can be confronted within collective environments.

This dissertation's introduction foregrounds the conceptual and theoretical framework for this argument, because it repositions disturbed sleep to not solely encompass psychological or physiological conditions, and instead places disturbed sleep discourse into a realm that analyzes it as a spatial and perceptual experience that is systematized by embodiment, environment, and cultural contexts. Drawing on Jean Ma's notions of threshold states, alongside the phenomenological approach of Maurice Merleau-Ponty and the anthropological framework of Arthur Kleinman, this dissertation argued that altered perceptual conditions emerged from the interaction between body and environment rather than from an isolated interiority alone.⁷⁵ At the same time, the discussion of folkloric narratives such as guǐ yā shēn (鬼压床, "ghost pressing") demonstrated how experiences associated with disturbed sleep are culturally mediated and historically situated, without minimizing the artworks themselves into a stereotype directed at illustrations of folklore. In the work of each of these artists, the experience of guǐ yā shēn (鬼压床) is depicted and further alchemized, transformed through the visual languages of

⁷⁵ Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191.

contemporary art into something that carries its cultural weight without being imprisoned by it. This process parallels the enduring perception of sleep paralysis as a supernatural phenomenon, a view that has inspired fear for centuries.⁷⁶ This raises the most significant question at the heart of this dissertation.⁷⁷ In that, how do you communicate a terror that lives in the body, in the language, in the inherited beliefs and the ancestral fears of a specific people, to an audience that may carry none of that within them? It is important to note that Sinophone culture has various folkloric and representative narratives that extend beyond a medical dialogue. The term *guǐ yā shēn* (鬼压床) is used to frame the study's understanding. There are many other stories and themes related to sleep disturbances within the Sinophone language, such as *jiangshi* (僵屍 or 殭屍), often referred to as "Chinese hopping zombies" or "Chinese hopping vampires." This understanding in the folkloric sense, while interesting, did not strengthen the dissertation. Instead, using this reference would make the central argument too complex. The artists chosen for this study do not examine sleepwalking, which is what *jiangshi* (僵屍 or 殭屍) is typically associated with, but is still a Sinophonic cultural phenomenon that I would be remiss if not included.

Across the practices analyzed in this dissertation, disturbed perceptual states are constructed through differing configurations of body, space, and duration. Each artist engages directly with motifs and affective states closely associated with *guǐ yā shēn* (鬼压床), and together, their practices span geographic, generational, and aesthetic boundaries that reflect both the historical weight and the contemporary transformation of these experiences.⁷⁸ Visual modes

⁷⁶ Brian A. Sharpless and Karl Doghramji, 'Chapter 4. Sleep Paralysis in Art and Literature,' *Sleep Paralysis: Historical, Psychological, and Medical Perspectives*, no. 1 (New York: Oxford Academic, 2015): 45-54, <https://doi.org/10.1093/med/9780199313808.003.0004>.

⁷⁷ Joshua G. Christensen, "Sleep Paralysis: Dreams, Demons and REM-Atonia," CUNY Academic Works, 2018, https://academicworks.cuny.edu/gj_etds/295.

⁷⁸ David J. Hufford, "Sleep Paralysis as Spiritual Experience," *Transcultural Psychiatry* 42, no. 1 (2005): 11, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1363461505050709>.

of disturbed sleep states are evidenced in this study as emerging from a single source. Through the research on performance, phenomenology, and psychoanalysis, contemporary Sinophone artists use their own mediums and materials to convey sleep disturbances in dynamic ways. While earlier chapters have examined and broken down these works individually, placing them in direct comparison reveals a more precise understanding of where and how perceptual instability is produced. Rather than locating disturbance mainly within the body or in the environment, these works demonstrate that such conditions arise through the dynamic interaction between the two.

In Duan Yingmei and Li Liao's performances, the body functions as a first-hand account and locus through which disturbance is introduced into space. However, the nature of this disturbance differs significantly in each case. Duan's performances, such as *Patience* (忍耐) (2004) and *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), construct perceptual instability through repetition and duration, increasingly disconcerting the temporal rhythms of public space (Figures 1 and 5). The performing body remains active, yet its gestures become gradually separated from a concise intention, creating a condition in which action persists without progression. Opposite to Duan, Liao's *Sleeping Bed 01 (Optics Valley)* (单人床 01 (光谷)) (2011) replaces repetition with stillness and thus narrates the body in a state of apparent withdrawal (Figure 9). It is within this placement that the disturbance is instantaneous rather than gradual. The presence of a prone body lying within the streets disrupts spatial expectations in a flash and, as a result, forms a tension between visibility and vulnerability. Moreover, these two case studies situate disturbed sleep as it is generated in its structural conditions of immobility, disorientation, and perceptual ambiguity, within a shared environment. Yingmei Duan approaches embodied liminality through radical stillness and withdrawal. Her performances enact the paralyzed body's suspension between

intention and immobility. Li Liao approaches the same threshold, however, from the opposite direction, engaging in relentless, compulsory activity that ultimately overwhelms the body and compels an involuntary surrender.

The work of Peng Wu brings a more focused attention to the body by testing its limits. Through endurance-based performances, Wu builds conditions in which the body is seen caught between control and collapse, subjected to continual pressure and constraint. Alternatively, from Duan's subtle temporal disruptions or Liao's spatial disjunctions, Wu's work intensifies the physical dimension of disturbance. The body stays present and visible, yet its capacity for action progressively diminishes, giving rise to a tension between persistence and exhaustion. This condition recalls the experience of forced stillness, in which awareness is maintained despite restricted movement. This configuration situates disturbance beyond the surrounding environment and into the body's inability to fully inhabit or respond to it.

In contrast, the staged photographic environments of Chen Wei relocate this instability from the body to space itself. His nocturnal interiors, characterized by artificial lighting and separating the environment from having human figures, manufacture environments that appear both familiar and estranged. Although the performances are discussed, these works are not solely reliant on bodily action or endurance. Instead, they frame perceptual disorientation through spatial arrangement, lighting, and the suspension of narrative. The absence of the body intensifies the work, leaving the viewer without orientation or a confounding resolution. Space takes on the position of the primary agent or disturbance, creating a condition in which perception is fragmented by the environment rather than by the actions of a visible subject. Chen Wei's practice can be understood as involving a performative construction of space. It is important to distinguish the phenomenological conditions through which photography operates

in relation to live performance. In the works of Duan Yingmei, Li Liao, and Peng Wu, perceptual disturbance emerges through duration, shared space, and the viewer's embodied co-presence with the performing body. Time unfolds in real experience, and perception is configured through waiting, endurance, and the gradual destabilization of spatial and temporal expectations.⁷⁹ By contrast, Wei's photographs operate through a fundamentally different structure. Although the environments are carefully staged and constructed before the moment of capture, the viewer encounters them as fixed images, in which time no longer unfolds. The phenomenological experience of the work is therefore opposite to durational in the same sense as performance, and is rather an accumulative and spatial encounter. This is evidenced by the viewer's gaze as it moves across the image, registering details, lighting, and compositional tensions in a process that unfolds internally instead of collectively. This produces a distinct form of perceptual instability, in which the absence of temporal progression is replaced by a heightened attention to spatial ambiguity and visual disorientation. This distinction is crucial for the argument of this dissertation. If performance constructs disturbed states through the manipulation of duration and embodied presence, Wei's photography demonstrates how similar conditions can be produced without real-time unfolding. The photograph does not replicate the temporal structure of performance. Instead, the temporal structure of performance compresses and reconfigures it, producing a suspended perceptual field in which disorientation emerges through the viewer's engagement with a constructed environment. In this sense, photography is not an extension of performance. Moreover, photography operates alongside performance as a distinct yet complementary mode through which disturbed perceptual states can be produced.

⁷⁹ Katherine Grube, "Bound Bodies: Performance Art in 1980s China," *Art in Translation* 17, no. 1 (2025): 1-20, <https://doi.org/10.1080/17561310.2025.2593052>.

The transformation from the body into the environment reveals a central insight in which disturbed perceptual states aren't inherited properties of either the body or space singularly, and rather emerges through their interaction. In Duan's and Liao's works, the body disrupts space; in Wu's, the body itself becomes disoriented under pressure, and in Wei's, space produces instability in the absence of the body. These differing approaches demonstrate that disturbance is not allocated to a fixed location; however, it is streamlined into a relational one, dependent on how bodily presence, spatial context, and temporal structure intersect.

Understanding disturbed states in this relational way further retranscribes how they might be connected to experiences of sleep. Rather than treating sleep as an internal or narrow space within psychological phenomena, these works' notion is that the perceptual conditions associated with it, such as immobility, disorientation, and temporal suspension, can be manufactured externally within collective spaces.⁸⁰ This aligns with Jean Ma's emphasis on the instability of perception at the threshold between waking and dreaming, while extending it beyond the cinematic frame into performance and spatial practice. At the same time, the frameworks of Maurice Merleau-Ponty and Arthur Kleinman underscore that these experiences are coherently embodied and contextually shaped, emerging through the interaction of perception, environment, and cultural meaning.⁸¹

Analyzed as a whole, these practices demonstrate that disturbed perceptual states are more than representative within contemporary Sinophone art and are rather actively manufactured through the manipulation of spatial and temporal conditions. Whether through

⁸⁰ Esther Olunu, "Sleep Paralysis, a Medical Condition with a Diverse Cultural Interpretation," *International Journal of Applied and Basic Medical Research* 8, no. 3, (2018): 137-142, https://doi.org/10.4103/ijabmr.IJABMR_19_18; Arthur Kleinman and Peter Benson, "Culture, Moral Experience and Medicine," *Mount Sinai Journal of Medicine* 73, no. 6 (2006): 834-839, <https://doi.org/10.1002/j.1944-0678.2006.tb02004.x>.

⁸¹ Jean Ma, *At the Edges of Sleep: Moving Images and Somnolent Spectators* (California: University of California Press, 2022), 1-191; Maurice Merleau-Ponty, "Phenomenology of Perception," *Philpapers.org*, 1945, <https://philpapers.org/rec/MERPOP-7>; Arthur Kleinman, "Culture, and Illness: A Question of Models," *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 1, no. 3 (1977): 229-31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00114790>.

repetition, stillness, endurance, or environmental construction, these works reshape the relationship between body and space, creating experiences that challenge stable distinctions between activity and passivity, as well as awareness and disorientation. It is within this changing relationship, and not within a single element, that disturbance is most fully realized.

The ensuing chapters augmented this framework through close analysis of performance and spatial practice. Chapter 1 substantiated how Yingmei Duan and Li Liao manipulate duration, stillness, and public space to manufacture conditions of visceral instability. In Duan's *Happy Yingmei* (快乐英梅) (2011), repetition and sustained duration increasingly disrupted the temporal rhythms of everyday environments, creating a state in which bodily action appeared increasingly detached from purposeful movement (Figure 6). Contrastingly, Li Liao's *Sleeping Bed 01 (Optics Valley)* (单人床 01 (光谷)) (2011) introduced disturbance through stillness and exposure, placing the body within public space in a way that unsettled the distinctions between private vulnerability and public visibility (Figure 9 and 10). In both of these cases, the body functioned oppositely from a symbolic representation of sleep, and took on an approach where the body served as a spatial mechanism through which altered states of awareness were built.

Chapter 2 turns the focus from bodily intervention to the role of the environment itself in creating perceptual disorientation. The endurance-based performances of Wu examine how physical constraint and sustained pressure fragment the body's capacity for orientation, manufacturing a condition suspended between agency and immobility. In contrast, the staged nocturnal environments of Wei position this instability in architectural and visual space, establishing atmospheres characterized by temporal suspension, artificial vibrancy, and estranged familiarity. While the work of Peng Wu foregrounds the body under pressure, Wei builds equally

unsettling conditions through the void of the body, permitting the space to become the locus of perceptual uncertainty.

As a whole, these works serve as evidence in which disturbed states associated with sleep surpass a basic representation within contemporary Sinophone art, and are instead situated as actively constructed through the manipulation of duration, repetition, bodily presence, and environmental structure. Across these practices, ordinary systems of spatial and temporal organization become unstable, transferring into experiences in which the distinctions between waking and sleeping, activity and passivity, as well as awareness and disorientation are rendered chaotic. Significantly, this imbalance is not treated as an abstract or universal phenomenon. Instead, the work's implicit altered perception within culturally and socially specific environments, evidencing how embodiment is formed through public space, labor, endurance, and collective experience.

Taken together, these findings call for a deep and urgent reconsideration of how contemporary art grapples with states of altered perception. Instead of treating sleep, dreaming, or unconsciousness as symbolic motifs or representational themes, the works explored here immerse us in these conditions, materially and spatially constructing them so that the viewer is drawn into a vivid, embodied experience. The implications reach far beyond the bounds of Sinophone art; they signal a sweeping transformation in contemporary practice, where perception itself emerges as the true canvas and battleground of artistic intervention. By boldly foregrounding the intricate interplay between body, space, and medium, this dissertation passionately intervenes in ongoing debates in art history and visual culture, challenging conventional notions of embodiment, spectatorship, and the very limits of representation. Ultimately, it contends that disturbed states are not passive images awaiting interpretation, nor

static. They are dynamic, generative conditions to be actively produced, realities that lay bare, disrupt, and radically reconfigure the frameworks through which perception is organized and reinvented across diverse artistic forms.

Nonetheless, certain limitations of this approach must be acknowledged. By emphasizing cross-cultural frameworks and comparative analysis, the study may risk underemphasizing nuances that are unique to individual artists or highly localized traditions.⁸² Furthermore, the reliance on a select group of case studies necessarily limits the scope of the conclusions that can be drawn about the broader field of Sinophone contemporary art, particularly as Sinophone studies have become increasingly interdisciplinary in recent years.⁸³ These constraints highlight the importance of future research that might engage a wider range of cultural practices or explore the perspectives of artists whose work falls outside the parameters of liminality as conceptualized in this dissertation.⁸⁴

Therefore, this dissertation contributes to existing scholarship by altering the discussion of sleep-related states away from metaphorical readings of ambiguity or “in-betweenness” and toward a more materially grounded analysis of how such conditions are spatially and performatively constructed. As a result of this, it argues that contemporary Sinophone performance and spatial practices allow for a distinct mode of engaging with disturbed perception, not through the depictions of dreams or unconscious imagery, and instead through the restructuring of the viewer’s experience of time, space, and bodily awareness itself.

⁸² Bok-yung Kim and Eun-joo Choi, "Contemporary Asian Art and Western Societies: Cultural 'Universalism' or 'Uniqueness' in Asian Modern Art," *Asian Journal of German and European Studies* 4, no. 1 (2019): 5, <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40856-019-0042-4>.

⁸³ Howard Chiang and Shu-Mei Shih, *Sinophone Studies Across Disciplines: A Critical Reader* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2024), 22.

⁸⁴ Shu-Mei Shih, "The Concept of the Sinophone," *PMLA* 135, no. 1 (Washington, DC: Walter Chapin Simpson Center for the Humanities at the University of Washington, 2011): 709-717, https://depts.washington.edu/uwch/documents/articles/Concept_of_the_Sinophone.pdf.

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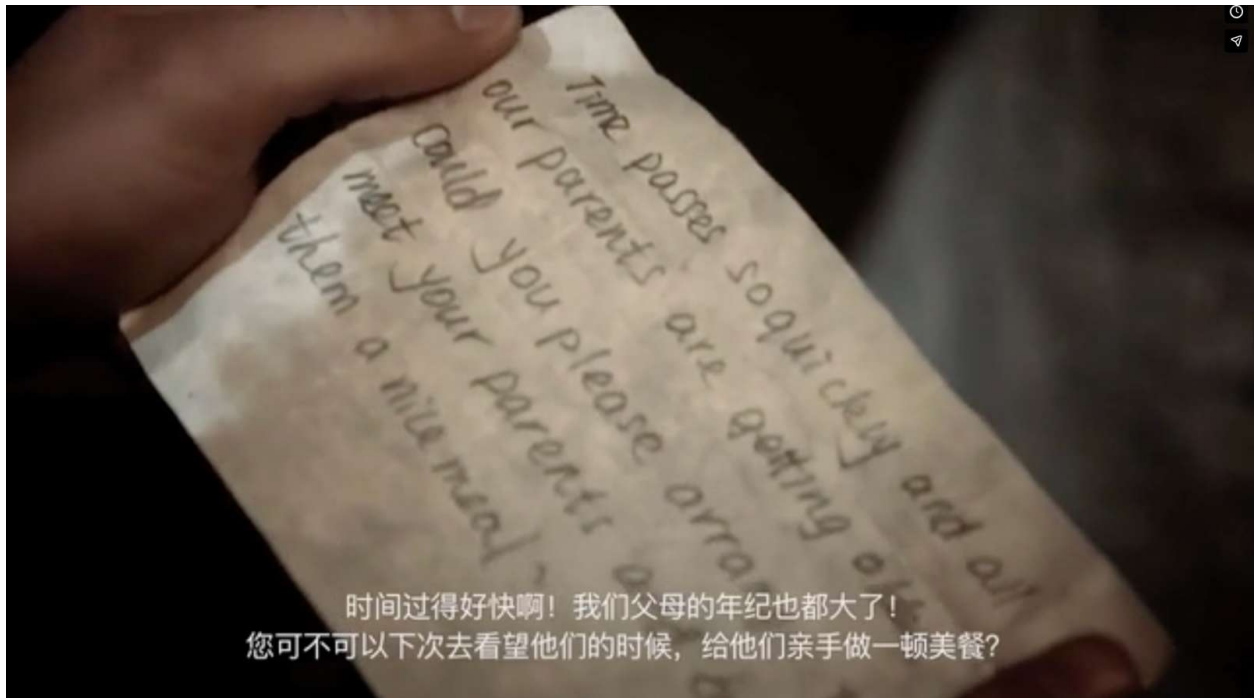


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